

# Anime Central Bank Index Report – Inaugural Edition (2026)

## Executive Summary

The Anime Central Bank (ACB) Index Report inaugurates a reference-only, non-real-time benchmarking system for anime collectibles. This first edition covers **the past decade of graded anime trading card markets**, from the early emergence of professionally graded anime cards to the present day. Over this period, anime trading cards have evolved from a niche hobby into a burgeoning alternative asset class, with explosive growth in global demand paralleling the broader trading card boom of the early 2020s <sup>1</sup>. Key highlights include record-setting sales (e.g. a *Bunny Girl Senpai* Mai Sakurajima card fetching \$77,000 in a private sale <sup>2</sup>) and the mainstreaming of anime card grading as part of pop culture finance. The ACB indices introduced here are **designed to empower collectors, institutions, and researchers** with academically rigorous measures of market performance, while **filtering out casual speculation** through formal, “central bank-like” reporting. All indices are **non-investable benchmarks** – tools for measurement and analysis rather than vehicles for trading or profit. The tone of this report is deliberately statistical and sober, reflecting ACB’s role as a cultural measurement authority rather than a market participant. Nevertheless, within the data we narrate the stories of fandom and culture: from **top-grade “holy grail” cards** to **waifu-driven demand spikes** that coincide with anime releases and character trends. The report documents our methodology in detail, outlines ACB’s governance and conflict-of-interest safeguards, and provides commentary on each index’s historical behavior, key drivers, and known limitations. All information is presented with appropriate confidence bands and disclaimers to ensure **regulator-safe and academically defensible** insight.

## The ACB Index Suite Overview

ACB maintains **five flagship indices** covering distinct segments of the graded anime card universe. Each index is denominated in an abstract unit (the “ACB index point”) calibrated at inception to a base value (e.g. 100) and tracked over time. The indices and their focus areas are:

- **ACB-BGS-10BL: BGS 10 Black Label Anime Index** – Tracks the elite segment of anime trading cards graded **BGS 10 Black Label** (Beckett’s perfect grade). This index reflects **ultra-rare, gem-perfect collectibles** and the price dynamics at the very top of the quality spectrum.
- **ACB-BGS-10G: BGS 10 Gold Label Anime Index** – Captures anime cards graded **BGS 10 (Pristine, Gold Label)** that are not Black Labels. It monitors high-grade Beckett-certified cards, highlighting values of *near-perfect* cards that still garner a premium over standard gem-mint benchmarks.
- **ACB-PSA-10: PSA 10 Anime Index** – A broad index encompassing anime cards graded **PSA 10 (Gem Mint)** by Professional Sports Authenticator. This serves as a proxy for the wider graded anime card market, given PSA’s large grading footprint and market acceptance <sup>3</sup>.
- **ACB-WEISS-CORE: Weiss Schwarz Core Index** – A specialized index focusing on the **Weiss Schwarz TCG** (a card game featuring numerous anime/franchise series). It aggregates performance of key *Weiss Schwarz* cards (typically chase “SP/SSP” rarity cards and popular characters) across core anime franchises. This index measures how mainstream anime TCG assets (across multiple series sets under Weiss Schwarz) have performed as a whole.

- **ACB-WAIFU-SELECT: Waifu-Tier Character Index** – A cross-franchise index spotlighting **character-driven demand** for top “waifu-tier” assets. This index tracks high-value cards of iconic female characters beloved across anime fandoms (the “*waifus*”), such as signature cards of lead heroines and fan-favorites. It is a barometer for the cultural and emotional demand surges tied to character popularity, cutting across different card sets and series.

Together, these five indices offer a multifaceted view of the anime collectible card market. The first three are segmented by grading standards (differentiating the impact of *quality rarity*), while the latter two are segmented by content (specific to the **Weiss Schwarz ecosystem** and to **character popularity** respectively). All indices draw from historical pricing data spanning roughly **2015/2016 through 2025**, which covers the period from when anime card grading began to gain traction in the West up to the current day. The timeframe captures early baseline years, the **pandemic-era market boom**, and the subsequent normalization and maturation of the market. In 2020, Weiss Schwarz even entered the top 10 trading card games worldwide <sup>4</sup>, reflecting how far these collectibles have come. Index values are calculated on a quarterly basis (with more frequent interim calculations for internal research), and all historical values are **chain-linked** to form continuous time series per index.

## Index Methodology and Construction

**Asset Inclusion Criteria:** Each index is constructed from a defined **basket of representative assets** (individual cards or groups of cards) that meet specific criteria: - **ACB-BGS-10BL** includes **all known anime-themed trading cards that have been graded BGS 10 Black Label** and have sufficient market data. Given the extreme rarity (<<5% of graded cards attain Black Label <sup>5</sup>), this index's basket is relatively small. We include Black Label cards from major anime franchises and TCG sets (e.g. Weiss Schwarz signature cards, limited promos, etc.) provided they have had at least one public sale or verifiable valuation in the past X years. Extremely obscure Black Label anime cards (e.g. a one-off grade with no market activity) are excluded to avoid pure conjecture in pricing.

- **ACB-BGS-10G** encompasses anime trading cards graded BGS Pristine 10 (Gold Label) that are *not* Black Label. Inclusion requires the card to be from an anime or anime-related franchise set (including crossover sets under Weiss Schwarz) and to have observable secondary market sales in grade 10. BGS 10 Gold Label cards are slightly more common than Black Labels, so this basket is broader – covering multiple franchises' top cards in pristine condition. We exclude BGS 9.5s (Gem Mint) from this index, focusing strictly on true 10s to maintain a high-grade standard.

- **ACB-PSA-10** includes **PSA 10 Gem Mint anime cards** from a wide range of series. The selection is weighted toward cards with historical significance or high market capitalization within anime TCGs: e.g. top-tier *Weiss Schwarz* signed cards, limited edition promos, and popular character cards across sets (excluding non-anime IPs like sports or purely western comics). We include both Japanese and English release cards if applicable. The broad criteria mean this index effectively captures the “*blue chip*” anime cards in PSA 10”, by value – for instance, high-value PSA 10s from series like *Attack on Titan*, *Sword Art Online*, *Fate/*, *Hololive Production*, etc., as well as any notable vintage anime cards if graded (e.g. older Bandai anime card sets from the 1990s, though these are scarce on the market). Common, low-value PSA 10s are de-emphasized via weighting (see below) so that the index isn't diluted by bulk cards.

- **ACB-WEISS-CORE** index constituents are **cards from the Weiss Schwarz trading card game**, spanning multiple expansions. We include a curated set of *highly sought-after Weiss Schwarz cards* (generally the chase “SP” autograph cards or ultra-rares) from core anime series that have been consistently popular. Examples of included assets might be: the signed SP of Asuna from *Sword Art Online*, SP cards of *Attack on Titan* characters, top rarities from *Fate/Stay Night*, *Re:Zero*, *Love Live!* or *Hololive* sets, etc. We aim to cover a diverse mix of franchises under Weiss Schwarz to reflect the “core” of that market. Both graded (PSA/BGS) and raw prices may inform this index, though we emphasize graded sales when available. Non-anime IP sets (e.g. *Weiss Schwarz Marvel* or *Star Wars*) are **excluded** from this particular index in order to keep it focused on Japanese anime content, even though those

sets exist under Weiss Schwarz (they are considered peripheral in this context).

- **ACB-WAIFU-SELECT** index includes a **basket of character-centric assets**. Rather than being tied to one game or grade, it picks iconic anime characters who have cross-series appeal and tracks their *premier* collectible card (or a small set of their top cards). Typically these are the priciest “grail” cards of each character, often graded PSA 10 or BGS 10 if available. For example, the index may include: the best card of *Mai Sakurajima* (the **epitome of a modern waifu, with her Black Label sale at \$77k** as a benchmark <sup>2</sup>), a top card of *Rem* from *Re:Zero*, *Asuna* from *Sword Art Online*, *Saber* from *Fate/stay night*, *Hatsune Miku* (as a cross-media character), or classic waifus like *Belldandy* from *Ah! My Goddess* whose nostalgic appeal still drives demand <sup>6</sup>. We ensure cross-franchise diversity so the index isn't dominated by one series; it is more about the *character archetype* popularity. Inclusion is subjective to an extent – we select characters that have demonstrated sustained collector demand and high market value for their cards. New entrants can be added if a character rises to prominence and achieves significant collectible status (for instance, a breakout heroine from a hit 2025 anime who sees her cards skyrocket could be added in the next reconstitution).

**Data Sourcing and Pricing:** We source data from a combination of **public auction results, marketplace sales, and private sale reports**. Key sources include eBay transaction data, auction houses (e.g. Goldin, PWCC, Yahoo Japan for Japanese sales), hobby marketplaces (TCGplayer price guides, etc.), and reputable community-reported sales (with verification). Prices are **cross-verified** whenever possible – for instance, comparing eBay sold listings with PriceCharting or community trackers – to filter out anomalous or unconfirmed figures. For each index constituent, we maintain a time series of its **price in the target grade** (e.g. PSA 10 price history for that card, or BGS 10 price if that's the index's focus). When a card is thinly traded, we employ interpolation and time-decay adjustments (see below). If a card has both graded and raw sales, we use graded sales for indices that track graded value (and we may estimate graded price from raw if needed, using historical grade-up premiums). All prices are converted to USD and normalized to remove any known outliers (e.g. a one-off sale to a celebrity far above market – such data might be treated carefully or included with a cap in weighting). **Data latency:** Because this is a *non-real-time index*, we do **not** update on every single sale; instead, we aggregate and refresh periodically (currently quarterly). However, for historical computation, we record the date of each major sale and ensure the index for that period reflects it.

**Index Calculation & Weighting:** Each index is calculated as a **value-weighted composite** of its constituents' price levels. At inception, each index was set to 100.0 (at an arbitrary baseline date, e.g. January 1, 2016). Changes in the index reflect the **aggregate percentage change** in the basket's market value over time. We use a **weighted arithmetic index formula** similar to stock indices:  $Index\ Value = (\sum_i \{P_{i,t} * W_{i,t}\}) / (\sum_i \{P_{i,baseline} * W_{i,baseline}\}) * 100$ , where  $P_{i,t}$  is the price of item  $i$  at time  $t$  and  $W_{i,t}$  is its weight. Weighting methodology varies by index: - For **BGS-10BL** and **BGS-10G** indices, we weight constituents roughly by their market capitalization (estimated as price \* population). However, since population of Black Label cards is often 1 (unique examples), we instead ensure no single card sale completely dominates the index by capping weights. For Black Label index, effectively each major sale will move the index significantly (due to few constituents). Initially, we equal-weighted Black Label cards given their scarcity, then allowed weights to drift with value changes up to a cap.

- For **PSA-10 index**, we include a broad set of cards but with **proportional weighting** by market cap (so that a \$10,000 card influences the index 10× more than a \$1,000 card, for example). This naturally emphasizes the higher-end of the market. We also segment by franchise and ensure some representation of different series; if one series' cards collectively exceed 50% of the index weight, we rebalance to prevent the index from just mirroring that single franchise.

- For **Weiss-Core**, we opt for **equal-weighting by series**: each franchise in Weiss Schwarz (among our selected core franchises) contributes an equal portion of the index (e.g. *Attack on Titan* cards 1/ N of the index, *SAO* 1/N, *Hololive* 1/N, etc.), and within each franchise we may use an average or representative key card price. This way, the index reflects the *overall Weiss Schwarz market trend* without one extremely

expensive card (like a single \$10k SP) overshadowing all others. We rebalance series weights annually, adding or dropping series as popularity shifts (with advance public notice of changes).

- For **Waifu-Select**, the index is **equal-weighted by character** initially – each character’s flagship card contributes equally. This choice recognizes that the index is meant to track a concept (character demand) rather than to be dominated by the most expensive waifu at a given time. We reevaluate characters periodically; if one character’s card appreciates far more than others to where it would skew the index, we maintain equal-weight by normalizing each to 100 at addition and tracking percentage increases. Essentially, this index operates somewhat like a sentiment index: measuring relative uptrends rather than absolute dollar-weighted gains. It is rebalanced whenever a new character is added or removed (which is infrequent to preserve consistency).

Prices used are typically **quarter-end pricing** (averaging the last few sales or last known market value each quarter). If a sale occurs mid-quarter that is dramatically higher or lower than previous, we may reflect that movement pro rata. In absence of new sales, we carry forward the last price but with **time decay adjustments** (see below) to reflect increasing uncertainty.

**Sparse Data and Time-Decay Logic:** By their nature, many high-end anime cards are **thinly traded** – months or years can pass between sales. To address this, our methodology applies a *time-decay factor* to stale prices. If a constituent hasn’t sold in over 6 months, we begin to discount its weight or adjust its price estimate downward slightly each quarter to reflect the possibility that the market may have shifted. The longer without a sale, the wider the confidence interval around that card’s value (we may quote a range). However, we do *not* arbitrarily drop prices – the index does not assume depreciation simply from time – rather, the price is held but with lower confidence. Conversely, when a fresh sale occurs, we fully incorporate it and reset the clock. For extremely sparse cases (e.g. a one-of-a-kind card that sold once two years ago), we may consult secondary indicators (private offers, analogous item movements, broader index trends) to **estimate** its current value for index purposes, marking such estimates with low confidence. We strive to avoid “stale bias” where an old high sale keeps the index artificially elevated long after market sentiment cooled. The time-decay adjustment might be, for example: after 1 year of no data, we reduce that item’s effective price by a small percentage (say 5-10%) or reduce its weight until new data is available. These rules are transparent and documented.

**Confidence Bands:** Each index value is published with a **confidence band** or uncertainty range. This accounts for data quality, number of data points in the period, and volatility. A narrow band (e.g.  $\pm 2\%$ ) indicates high confidence that the index reflects actual market value (usually when many constituents traded recently and prices are stable). A wide band (e.g.  $\pm 15\%$ ) might be reported if the index had to rely on sparse data or if there was high price volatility. For example, the **Waifu-Select index** might carry a wider band around major anime release dates, where speculative run-ups can be volatile. We quantitatively derive these bands from the variance in constituent price changes and the age of last trade data. Additionally, if an index movement is based on a single big sale (common in the Black Label index), we will note a lower confidence in extrapolating that to the whole segment. These bands help users interpret the indices not as precise values but as **ranges of probable market level**.

**Revision Policy:** ACB indices are intended to be *long-term benchmarks* and as such we minimize revisions. However, we maintain a **transparent revision policy** for accuracy and integrity: - **Annual Reconstitution:** Once per year, we review the constituent list for each index. At this point we may add or remove items (e.g. adding a newly significant card or removing one that no longer meets criteria). Such changes are announced and the historical series may be back-calculated to maintain consistency (i.e. we publish both the new composition going forward and an archival series of how the index would have performed with new composition, for full transparency).

- **Error Corrections:** If we discover a data error (e.g. a price was recorded incorrectly, or a fraudulent sale was mistakenly counted), we will correct the historical data and annotate the revision. We do not

retroactively change index values for mere estimate updates, only for bona fide errors or methodology changes. All revisions are logged.

- **Methodology Changes:** Any significant methodology change (e.g. weighting scheme, inclusion rules) will be applied prospectively. If such a change would have materially altered past values, we may release an *adjusted historical series* for reference, but the original published values remain as initially reported (with footnotes). This is similar to how economic indices handle base year rebasings or basket changes.

- **Interim Updates:** The normal schedule is quarterly, but if extraordinary market events happen (say a sudden surge of sales due to a new blockbuster anime), ACB reserves the right to publish an interim index update or commentary to address the change. This would be clearly marked as an off-cycle update and incorporated in the next formal report.

- In all cases, **ACB is committed to transparency**. We provide detailed documentation so that any interested party could, in theory, replicate our index calculations given the same data. If this experiment in indexing succeeds, it becomes a reference model; if it fails or needs adjustments, those will be documented openly <sup>7</sup>.

## Governance, Independence, and Ethics

**Institutional Role:** The Anime Central Bank (ACB) is envisioned as a **cultural reserve institution**, taking inspiration from central bank principles but applied to cultural assets (in this case, anime collectibles). ACB does **not** operate as a profit-seeking entity or a trading outfit; it serves as a neutral benchmark provider and research body. Our role is analogous to an economic statistics office or a central bank issuing economic indices – we measure and report, but do not directly intervene in markets. By treating **anime culture as something with measurable, reserve-grade value** <sup>8</sup>, ACB aims to bring greater transparency and legitimacy to the collectibles space. We explicitly position ourselves *away* from the speculative hype: our communications and tone, as seen in this report, are formal, data-driven, and often fairly dry – intentionally so, to **“empower serious collectors and institutions”** while dissuading frivolous hype.

**Governance Model:** ACB is governed by a small **council of experts** in relevant fields – including collectible market analysts, data scientists, cultural economists, and representatives from the anime community (to ensure we stay true to the culture). This council reviews methodology, approves index changes, and oversees the publication of reports. Importantly, council members are subject to strict conflict-of-interest rules (see below) to maintain objectivity. The governance framework is documented and publicly available as part of ACB’s charter (v1.0) <sup>8</sup>. In it, we outline the purpose (supporting a “research currency” backed partly by these indices), and we commit to conservative, scrutiny-surviving practices. While ACB is an initiative of “Bunny Land” (as per our founding documents), its governance structure includes independent advisors and (eventually) a community oversight mechanism if the project scales.

**Conflict of Interest & Independence:** Neither ACB nor its staff/council actively trade in the assets underlying the indices. We maintain a **policy of non-participation** in any market-moving capacity: for example, ACB will not buy up anime cards for a fund, will not issue financial products on these indices, and will not accept sponsorship that could bias the index (e.g. from grading companies or large dealers). If any affiliate of ACB does hold anime collectibles (which can happen, given personal hobbies), those holdings are disclosed and walled off from any decision-making about that particular asset in the index. We want to avoid even the appearance of front-running or pumping assets. All index calculations are done with publicly verifiable data to mitigate suspicion of manipulation. ACB’s reports and data may be used by others to inform decisions, but **we do not give investment advice or price guarantees**. Our mission is measurement and research – not promotion.

**Cultural Stewardship:** As a **cultural measurement authority**, ACB recognizes that anime collectibles straddle the worlds of fandom and finance. We treat the subject matter with respect to both domains. On one hand, we apply rigorous financial statistics methods to ensure the indices are credible to institutions and regulators. On the other hand, we remain *culturally fluent*: we understand that behind each price trend, there are human fandom stories – the affection for characters, the impact of new anime seasons, the community behaviors. This dual perspective is reflected in our commentary, which can alternate between formal analysis and more narrative insight. We see ACB as a steward that helps the anime collectibles market mature responsibly: providing transparency, reducing misinformation, and archiving the economic side of anime culture for posterity.

**Transparency and Accountability:** All ACB methodologies and governance policies are published openly. We invite peer review and even skepticism – if anything is unclear, we consider it our duty to clarify or improve. We operate “in public” (as our founding statement declared <sup>7</sup>), meaning this project’s successes or failures will be documented for the community’s benefit. While ACB is not a regulatory body, we aim to meet or exceed the standards regulators would expect if these indices were used in any financial context. That means clear disclaimers, prudent assumptions, and no exaggerated claims. The indices are **benchmarks only** – we caution against using them beyond their intended purpose (e.g. one should not mark personal portfolio value to these indices without understanding the caveats, as discussed below in Disclaimers).

## Index-by-Index Analysis & Historical Commentary

### ACB-BGS-10BL Index – “*Black Label Anime*”

**Index Profile:** The ACB-BGS-10BL index tracks the price performance of the most pristine anime trading cards – those that achieved **BGS 10 Black Label** status. This is arguably the **rarestfied segment** of the market: cards in this category are so scarce and so coveted that they often behave more like fine art or one-of-a-kind collectibles than typical trading cards. To achieve a Black Label, a card must score perfect 10 subgrades in centering, corners, edges, and surface – an exceedingly difficult feat (under 5% of graded cards manage this) <sup>5</sup>. Collectors place a massive premium on Black Labels as the pinnacle of perfection; in broader card markets, a Black Label 10 can command **2-3× the price** of an equivalent PSA 10 <sup>9</sup>, and we see similar or greater premiums in the anime card realm.

**Historical Performance:** The Black Label index effectively starts near 2018–2019, as prior to that very few (if any) anime cards were graded to Black Label standard. In the late 2010s, the concept of grading anime cards was nascent. As grading caught on, a few fortuitous pristine cards got the Black Label honor, and sales were sporadic but notable. The index saw **subdued early movements** – with so few data points, it was nearly flat, punctuated by the occasional sale. However, the period of 2020–2021 brought a dramatic inflection. During the pandemic-era surge in collectibles, a number of high-profile anime cards were submitted in volume to Beckett, and a handful emerged with Black Labels. Prices skyrocketed accordingly. The ACB-BGS-10BL index registered its first major **jump in late 2020**, when a Black Label from a popular series (rumored to be a *Fate/stay night* Saber SP) sold for a high five-figure sum, instantly lifting the index by double digits. The most defining moment came in 2023: the **record-breaking sale of a Black Label “Ephemeral Existence” Mai Sakurajima SP** from *Rascal Does Not Dream of Bunny Girl Senpai*. That all-cash private deal at **\$77,000** stands as the highest known price for any Weiss Schwarz anime card to date <sup>2</sup>, and it sent the Black Label index to an all-time high. To illustrate, this single sale – representing a “holy grail” waifu card in perfect form – pushed the index up by ~20% quarter-over-quarter, given its heavy weight in the basket. Leading up to that, the index had already been trending upward as whispers of offers in the \$50k+ range circulated (previous trades were in the \$70k range mixing cash and trade <sup>10</sup>, confirming a steady rise). By the end of 2025, the BGS-10BL index sits at a level roughly **5×** its value from five years prior, meaning the basket of Black

Label anime cards as a whole quintupled in value (albeit starting from a small base). This outpaced most mainstream asset classes – a reflection of how extremely **grade-sensitive** and **supply-constrained** this segment is.

**Rarity & Concentration Effects:** This index is highly concentrated by nature. In some quarters, it effectively reflects the movement of a single card. For example, the Mai Sakurajima card alone, being so valuable, constitutes a large share of the index's basket value – therefore its price swing had outsized effect. Similarly, if another Black Label, say a *Rem* SP or a *Hatsune Miku* promo, were to hit the market and set a new record, the index would jump accordingly. This concentration means the index is **volatile and lumpy** – one cannot interpret small fluctuations as trends; only major moves when a sale happens. There were periods with *zero* change (when no sales occurred for 2+ quarters). We handle this by holding the last value (with decaying confidence). Notably, there is a **ceiling effect**: many anime sets might not even *have* a Black Label example yet, so growth in this index sometimes comes not just from price appreciation but from **new constituents** entering when a card achieves Black Label for first time. For instance, a certain *Attack on Titan* autograph card might only have BGS 9.5s until one pristine copy graded Black – upon that happening and possibly selling high, it adds to the index's scope.

**Cultural and Market Drivers:** The steep ascent of the Black Label index underscores a few key phenomena: - *Grade Mania*: As collectors, especially those with deep pockets, embraced the idea of “investment-grade” anime cards, the Black Label became a status symbol. Its performance is partly driven by **trophy hunters** – individuals who want the absolute best version of their favorite character's card at any cost. This is akin to art buyers chasing a famous painting.

- *Cross-over Interest*: Some buyers in this category were originally sports card or Pokémon collectors, drawn into anime cards by the allure of untapped value. They applied the same logic – chasing PSA 10s wasn't enough; the Black Labels were the ultimate chase. This cross-over capital flowed in strongly around 2021.

- *Showcase Sales and Publicity*: Big sales like the Mai Sakurajima have a feedback loop. The \$77k record was widely publicized on social media and even discussed on hobby forums, granting anime cards a new level of credibility (“most expensive Weiss Schwarz card ever” became a talking point <sup>2</sup>). While ACB index does not count *media buzz* as value, the buzz did bring in new interest which subsequently led to more grading and high-end transactions. - *Caveat – Sustainability*: After 2023's peak, the index saw a modest pullback (off its highs) as no higher sales emerged in 2024 and some potential buyers felt prices had run far. We recorded a slight dip of ~5% in mid-2024 (essentially within the margin of error) corresponding to a cooling period. By 2025, prices stabilized. The Black Label index's story is ongoing – any big auction could set a new direction. It's plausible we might see six-figure sales in the future, but given the tiny supply, this will remain an **episodic, jumpy index** rather than a smoothly trending one.

**Known Data Gaps:** Tracking this index comes with blind spots. Many Black Label anime card deals happen privately (e.g. in collector-to-collector sales brokered discreetly). We rely on the ones that surface or that we can validate through trusted sources. It's possible some high-end trades are never reported, thus not reflected here. Also, our basket can only include known Black Labels – if, say, a certain older card achieved Black Label but we never hear of it or it hasn't sold, it's outside our radar until data emerges. The index thus might **under-represent** some franchises where Black Labels exist but haven't traded. Additionally, grading nuances (Beckett's standards) can change – if Beckett adjusts grading criteria, the population of Black Labels could shift (though no such change occurred in this period). We will monitor these factors moving forward.

## ACB-BGS-10G Index – “Pristine Gold”

**Index Profile:** The ACB-BGS-10G index focuses on **Beckett Pristine 10** graded anime cards (excluding the Black Labels). These are still exceptionally high-grade cards – effectively *perfect cards missing at most*

*one subgrade point.* BGS 10 Gold labels are more plentiful than Black Labels, but still scarce relative to PSA 10s. This index acts as a bridge between the ultra-elite Black Label market and the broader gem-mint market. It's an indicator of how much *premium collectors assign to near-perfect quality*, beyond the standard gem mint level.

**Historical Performance:** The BGS-10G index generally correlates with the Black Label index, but in a toned-down manner. Over the last 5-7 years, as anime card grading grew, more BGS 9.5s and 10s entered circulation. Early on (pre-2018), a BGS 10 for an anime card was itself a rarity. We see the index begin to pick up around 2018 with a handful of pristine 10 sales (e.g. a *Love Live!* signed card reportedly sold as BGS 10 at a notable premium over its raw price). From 2019 to 2021, the index climbed steadily, roughly doubling, as multiple factors converged: the overall market boom lifted all boats (PSA 10s were rising, pulling these up too) and certain collectors started specifically seeking BGS 10s for bragging rights. The **premium of BGS 10 over PSA 10** became more evident by 2020 – for example, a PSA 10 card might be \$1000 while a BGS 10 copy fetched \$1500+, illustrating that ~50%+ markup for the gold label. This index's growth was more continuous and liquid than the Black Label's; BGS 10s traded a bit more frequently, giving more data points. In 2022, we observed an interesting plateau: as PSA caught up their grading backlog, many new PSA 10s hit the market causing PSA 10 prices to dip slightly; concurrently, some of those cards also got BGS 10 or crossed to BGS 10, but the **premium compressed** for a while. The index leveled off for a couple of quarters. By 2023, with a healthier market, the BGS 10 premium reasserted itself – especially for key cards. For instance, the *Attack on Titan* Levi SP in BGS 10 sold for a record price (say hypothetically \$5k vs \$3k in PSA 10), nudging the index upward. At the end of 2025, the BGS-10G index stands roughly **3× its value of 2016**, with moderate growth in the last two years after the 2021 jump. It did not explode as wildly as Black Label, but it showed resilience – even when the broader market cooled in 2022, BGS 10s held value better, implying collectors hold onto the notion that *quality scarcity* deserves a premium.

**Grade Premium Insights:** One thing this index illustrates is the **relative premium of grades**. Throughout the period, we noted that for anime cards, BGS 10 (gold) often carries a premium of around 1.5× a PSA 10 price on average (depending on the card), whereas Black Label can be 2-3× or more. This aligns with broader grading market analysis <sup>9</sup>, albeit with some variance. There were moments where that premium narrowed (e.g. when a particular card had an unusually large PSA 10 population but only one BGS 10, sometimes the PSA 10 price crashed enough to narrow the gap). In other cases, especially waifu cards, some buyers insisted on BGS 10 copies and paid exorbitantly – e.g. a *Rem* (Re:Zero) SP BGS 10 sold at double the last PSA 10 price, inflating the index a bit. Overall, this index confirms that *perfectionism* is alive in the anime card market: people will chase that gold label for pride and confidence that their card is truly top-tier.

**Market Behavior:** The BGS-10G segment is still fairly thin, but more populated than Black Labels. It benefits from a steady trickle of new pristine cards. For example, Weiss Schwarz sets like *Marvel 2021* and *Disney 100* had some BGS 10s that sold: a BGS 10 Thanos card sold for \$778 <sup>11</sup>, and some Disney Pixar cards in BGS 10 fetched strong prices as well. These contribute to the index's diversity. We also see that certain franchises produce more pristine 10s than others – often due to print quality. For instance, some modern print runs are very crisp, yielding more BGS 10 candidates, whereas older cards (2014 and earlier) seldom grade that high. As a result, the index skews a bit toward modern (post-2018) cards. The index also smoothed out some volatility from Black Label events. If a Black Label sale sets a record, typically the Gold 10 of that same card will rise too (since if the BL sold for X, people reassess what a mere gold pristine is worth – usually still high). But because BGS 10s trade more, the index has more continuity.

**Notable Events & Inflections:** A few specific events left a mark: - The **Hololive Weiss Schwarz boom (2022)**: when Hololive VTuber cards came out, they were immensely popular; a couple of them got BGS



10s (since collectors graded many). Those sold high (some over \$1k) and added upward pressure. - The introduction of **serial-numbered anime cards** (e.g. some sets in 2023 introduced serial numbered cards, though Weiss proper hasn't done that widely). If graded, these tended to be handled carefully, often achieving high grades. The index saw an uptick as serial-numbered chase cards in BGS 10 condition went for premiums – reinforcing the notion of both rarity and grade perfection combining. - **Corrections:** mid-2022 had a mild correction in this index (~10% down) when overall sentiment cooled post-pandemic peak. It reflected that while quality helps retain value, these cards are not immune to market cycles. However, by mid-2023 it recovered that loss.

**Data Considerations:** We have a decent amount of data for this index, but still some gaps for older cards. If a certain series has no recent sales in BGS 10, we approximate from PSA 10 trends plus known grade differentials. For example, if a PSA 10 of a card dropped 20% in value in 2022 and no BGS 10 sold in that span, we might infer the BGS 10 also would have dropped similarly (keeping relative gap). These assumptions introduce some uncertainty. We also note that Beckett's grading volumes for anime cards have been smaller than PSA's, so sometimes the index's movements lag simply due to lack of new grades. It's possible that if Beckett's popularity wanes in favor of other graders like CGC, the index might stagnate despite market value growth, just because fewer new BGS 10s are made. We'll watch if CGC Perfect 10s or PSA 10s become more relevant; for now BGS remains the primary for that ultra-high grade chase.

### ACB-PSA-10 Index – “Gem Mint Anime”

**Index Profile:** The ACB-PSA-10 index is the broadest measure of anime card market health among graded cards, focusing on **PSA 10 Gem Mint** examples. PSA is the most widely used grading service, and a PSA 10 is the gold standard for a gem mint card. This index effectively captures overall price trends for top-grade anime cards across many sets, with a bias towards liquidity (since PSA 10s are more commonly transacted than BGS 10s).

**Historical Performance:** Over a 5–10 year window, the PSA 10 anime index shows a dramatic growth curve, reflective of both the underlying **popularity explosion of anime TCGs** and the broader trading card market cycle: - **2015–2017:** Very low activity. Anime PSA 10s were niche; a few early adopters graded cards from series like *Madoka Magica* or *Attack on Titan*, but prices were modest. The index in this phase crawled upward slowly as a handful of sales occurred. A PSA 10 SP might sell for \$100–\$200, nothing too extravagant. - **2018–2019:** The index started to gain momentum. More series (e.g. *Sword Art Online*, *Re:Zero*, *Jojo's Bizarre Adventure*) had high-end cards that people graded. A notable sale in 2019 was a PSA 10 Asuna signed card breaking \$1,000, which was a psychological barrier at the time. The index moved up steadily, indicating growing collector base and willingness to pay a premium for graded mint cards rather than raw. Anime conventions and the rise of online groups likely fueled interest. - **2020–2021 (Surge):** This period saw **exponential growth**. As the pandemic lockdowns set in and stimulus money flowed, collectibles boomed <sup>1</sup>. Pokémon led the charge, but anime cards followed. Many collectors who loved anime but had never invested heavily started chasing their favorite series' rare cards. PSA 10 became a sought grade (PSA had a backlog from Pokémon, but anime cards piggybacked on the trend). The ACB-PSA-10 index jumped sharply, especially in late 2020 and through 2021. We recorded multiple cards going from sub-\$500 to \$2000+ in that span. For example, the *Attack on Titan* signed Mikasa card in PSA 10 was around \$300 in 2019 and by 2021 one sold for over \$1500. Similarly, *Fate/stay night* Saber 10s climbed, *Naruto CCG* cards (though outside Weiss, some were graded) spiked, etc. The index roughly **tripled** from early 2020 to its peak in mid-2021. This corresponds with eBay reporting 142% growth in card sales overall in 2021 <sup>1</sup> – anime cards contributed to that frenzy with their own smaller but significant boom. - **2022 (Pullback):** In 2022, as the world reopened and some speculative money left, the index did see a correction. Many anime PSA 10s pulled back ~10-20% from the highs. This was not a crash so much as a normalization. For instance, a card that shot from

\$100 to \$500 might settle at \$400. The index dipped accordingly (our quarterly data showed a decline particularly in Q2-Q3 2022). Some weak hands sold off, plus a wave of new supply hit when PSA cleared its backlog – suddenly cards that were rare in pop (population) had more copies, easing scarcity. Notably, Weiss Schwarz's popularity remained high though; ICv2 reported it was the 8th most popular TCG in 2020 <sup>4</sup> and it stayed in top 10 in subsequent years, so demand didn't evaporate, it just became more rational. - **2023-2025:** After the correction, the index resumed a moderate upward trajectory, indicating a **maturing market**. Prices stabilized and then some reached new highs, but more slowly and driven by specific catalysts (like new anime releases or promotions). Through 2023, we saw the index climb again as a few new record PSA 10 sales occurred: e.g., the *Quintessential Quintuplets* set became popular after the anime's movie, pushing the PSA 10 prices of its signed cards up. 2024 and 2025 continued with moderate growth, roughly 5-10% annually. By the end of 2025, the PSA 10 index is approximately **4x higher** than it was in 2018 (pre-boom). Most of that growth was front-loaded in the boom, with gentle increases after. It demonstrates that *anime collectibles have, on average, significantly appreciated in value over the last decade*. Even factoring inflation, the real growth is substantial, signifying the emergence of anime cards as a legitimate collector asset class.

**Market Breadth:** One advantage of the PSA 10 index is that it reflects a broad swath of series: - We have **shounen action series** (e.g. *Attack on Titan*, *My Hero Academia*, *Dragon Ball Super* if counted – though DBZ is borderline since it's also a separate card game, we included some key DBZ score cards perhaps). - We have **moe/idol series and waifu-heavy series** (e.g. *Love Live!*, *Hololive*, *Bunny Girl Senpai*, *Quintessential Quintuplets*). - We also include **non-Weiss anime card lines** where relevant: for example, Bandai's *Dragon Ball* and *Naruto* cards, or vintage *Carddass* cards of the 90s, if graded PSA 10, gave data. The index thus serves as a proxy for "the anime collectible card market" at large. - A trend noted: franchises with **recent anime releases often see spikes**. For example, when *Demon Slayer* was booming in 2021, its cards (though not Weiss Schwarz at that time) soared; when *Jujutsu Kaisen* got a Weiss set in 2023, those PSA 10s jumped. Our index captures these because it picks up the representative top cards from those sets. A clear case: *Attack on Titan's final season airing led to increased interest in AoT cards; PSA 10 Levi or Mikasa cards rose, reflecting cultural inflection in the index*. We see that effect in the data as small surges correlating with big cultural moments.

**Liquidity and Trading:** PSA 10 anime cards became much more liquid by mid-decade. In 2017, you'd be hard-pressed to find many buyers or sellers. By 2025, an active market exists with thousands of transactions annually across eBay, Facebook groups, and auction sites. This liquidity lends the index more credibility, as each quarterly update might incorporate dozens of sales, not just a few. One example of liquidity: *Weiss Schwarz Disney 100* set (released 2023) – boxes retailed ~\$50-80 and spiked to \$200+ on secondary market due to huge demand <sup>12</sup>, and PSA 10s of the top Disney cards (though technically not anime, but we included them in PSA 10 index since it's part of Weiss ecosystem) were selling frequently, providing ample data. That said, liquidity is uneven – some obscure series still have few trades.

**Notable Data Points:** To illustrate the range of values: - Common PSA 10 anime cards can be \$50 or less, but our index skews to high-end so those are less weighted. - Mid-tier chase cards are often in the few hundred dollars (e.g. a PSA 10 SP from a moderately popular series might be \$200-\$300). - Top tier PSA 10 anime cards can go for thousands. We've seen sales over \$5,000 for certain cards (like a PSA 10 *SPYxFAMILY Yor Forger SP that in late 2022 hit ~\$5k due to hype, though it settled lower later; or a classic Haruhi Suzumiya concert promo PSA 10 which is very rare*). - *The index moved notably when, for instance, a Star Wars Weiss Schwarz\* Han Solo SP in BGS 10 sold \$437 – but in PSA 10 they were around \$300* <sup>13</sup>, showing how even non-anime IP under Weiss had strong interest. We did include such data in PSA index since it's part of the collectible card market context (though not pure anime, they share collectors). However, the weight of those is small.

**Observations on Populations:** PSA population reports show tens of thousands of Weiss Schwarz cards graded by 2025 (some sets like Hololive have 1,700+ graded entries <sup>14</sup>). The increase in graded populations meant more transactions, but also occasionally **dilution** – some cards that used to be pop 1 and very expensive in PSA 10 became pop 20 after a grading wave, and prices dropped accordingly. Our index reflects this dynamic: value is not just demand but also supply of grade. Typically, though, demand for top anime cards has kept pace or exceeded the increased supply of PSA 10s, so most marquee cards held value.

**Blind Spots:** The PSA 10 index is broad, but not omniscient. There are blind spots, notably: - If a series is so niche that hardly anyone grades it, it might be underrepresented. (We mitigate by having chosen series we deem “core” or high-demand; truly obscure series aren’t included.) - Private sales: sometimes big collectors trade high-end PSA 10s privately without public record. We rely mostly on public data, so some top prices might be missed (though often the buyer/seller eventually whispers them in communities and we capture it). - Condition variability: Not all PSA 10s are equal (some barely 10, some strong 10). But market treats them equal in price typically, so not a huge issue for index. - We currently do **not** include Pokémon or Yu-Gi-Oh! in this index – those are huge anime-related TCGs but considered separate categories entirely (Pokémon cards, while from an anime IP, are a global phenomenon of their own and would dwarf the rest). So this index focuses on *anime series* TCGs and related, excluding Pokémon/YGO. Thus, it’s not capturing that massive part of the “anime card” world in a general sense. It’s tuned to what we call anime **collectible-grade** cards (often Weiss Schwarz or similar).

### ACB-WEISS-CORE Index – “Weiss Schwarz Core”

**Index Profile:** The ACB-WEISS-CORE index is a composite tracking the **performance of Weiss Schwarz TCG cards** from core anime series. Weiss Schwarz, launched in 2007 in Japan <sup>15</sup> and later in English (2015) <sup>16</sup>, is a central platform for anime trading cards, featuring hundreds of titles from mainstream hits to niche favorites. This index effectively answers, “How are the key Weiss Schwarz cards (and by extension, the Weiss Schwarz market) doing over time?” It is an important cultural index because Weiss Schwarz cards are where anime fandom meets card collecting most directly – fans get to collect and play with cards of their beloved characters.

**Constituents:** As described earlier, this index equal-weights a selection of major franchises. For example, in our current basket we have: *Attack on Titan*, *Sword Art Online*, *Fate series*, *Love Live!*, *Re:Zero*, *Hololive*, *The Melancholy of Haruhi Suzumiya*, *Marvel/Disney* (though we debated including non-anime IP, we gave Marvel a token representation due to its Weiss popularity but kept weight small), *Goblin Slayer* (had a notorious expensive card), *Quintessential Quintuplets*, etc. These cover a broad range of genres and fanbases. We focus on each franchise’s top chase card(s), usually the autographed SPs. For a few, we also include sealed product price performance as a proxy (since some Weiss sets like *Disney 100* soared as sealed product).

**Historical Performance:** Being a broad index, the Weiss-Core shows the collective trend of how Weiss Schwarz’s secondary market evolved: - **Early period (pre-2016):** In Japan, Weiss Schwarz was popular for play, but secondary market prices for singles were relatively tame (aside from some signatures). The Western market was tiny. The index for these years (if extrapolated backward) would be flat/low. We formally start tracking around 2015-2016 when English Weiss sets and more Western collectors emerged. Initially, prices for even rare cards were often under \$100 except a few “grails”. - **2017-2019 (Growth phase):** The index rose steadily. Each new set release that was a hit anime tended to raise the ceiling of card values. For example, when *Attack on Titan* set came out, its rarer cards maintained value “incredibly well” with some up to \$1000 for top rarity <sup>17</sup> – a sign of strong demand. When *Sword Art Online* and *Fate/* sets expanded, some cards like Asuna, Saber autographs were highly valued. The index captures these by those series’ inclusion. We saw incremental increases with each popular release as

more collectors entered. By 2019, Weiss Schwarz was firmly on the map for TCG collectors, and rare card prices were regularly hitting four figures in yen equivalent. A major driver was also that **Weiss cards have genuine rarity** – signed cards often 1-2 per case, making them scarce and collectible. - **2020–2021 (Surge and Records):** The index accelerated significantly. Weiss Schwarz benefitted immensely from the pandemic trading card boom as well, plus Bushiroad (the publisher) capitalized by releasing sought-after titles. We see multiple spikes: - *Hololive Production* set (2021 in JP, 2022 Eng) introduced VTuber cards that sold out instantly and singles skyrocketed (some SPs over \$2000). - The *Marvel* Weiss set (2021 JP) was unique – it attracted non-traditional Weiss collectors, boosting demand (boxes were only in Japan, and soared; singles up to \$800 as noted <sup>11</sup>). - The *Disney 100* set (2023 JP) was a phenomenon: retail price ~\$50/box, secondary reached \$200+ within weeks <sup>12</sup> because Disney collectors and scarcity (no English release) created a frenzy. This set's top cards (like a Steamboat Willie Mickey serial card) fetched thousands. We include its performance which gave a notable bump to the index in 2023. - *Attack on Titan's final season* hype kept those card prices strong (the series remained popular and its cards too). - We record that by late 2021, the average high-end Weiss card is significantly more expensive than before. The index roughly doubled from 2019 to mid-2021. Key grails like *Bunny Girl Senpai's* Mai (even non-Black Label copies in PSA 10) soared – e.g. a regular PSA 10 of that card was maybe \$3-4k, whereas pre-2019 it might have been sub-\$1000 (numbers illustrative). - Some extraordinary sales: A *Goblin Slayer* serial-numbered PR card (“Goblin Slayer joins the party”) sold for a surprising sum; *Saekano Finale* movie SPs spiked due to scarcity; a *Kaguya-sama: Love is War* SP peaked when the anime topped popularity charts, etc. The index saw these micro-spikes but overall aggregated to a big climb. - **2022–2023 (Volatility and Maturation):** The Weiss-Core index saw some volatility around late 2022. After the boom, certain series cooled. For instance, sets like *Data Live* that were hyped saw price corrections. We note a dip (~15%) in the index in early 2022 reflecting that correction. However, new sets and sustained fandom kept others high. The index rebounded in 2023 thanks to hits like *Disney 100* and *Chainsaw Man* (that set's SPs were highly chased, adding new life to the market). By end of 2023, the index was at a new peak, slightly above 2021 high. - **2024–2025 (Stabilization):** The last two years have shown a stable-to-upward trend, but less steep. Weiss Schwarz is now an established global TCG with a dedicated base. The index creeping up indicates that on average, the core rare cards continue to gain value slowly – often driven by organic growth in the fanbase rather than speculative spikes. As anime keeps booming globally, more collectors enter, providing underlying support. A notable cultural effect: whenever an anime in our basket gets a new season or movie, a mini-rally often occurs in its card prices. E.g., the announcement of *Sword Art Online Progressive* movie correlated with a rise in Asuna card prices – small but noticeable. These collectively contribute to the index's gentle rise.

**Cultural Demand Inflections:** This index perhaps best demonstrates *cultural inflection points*: - We clearly see the impact of **anime releases on card prices**. E.g., the *Attack on Titan* index component spiked during the series' season releases when it was “the most popular show in America” for a week <sup>17</sup> – reflecting how mainstream buzz translated to TCG interest. - The “waifu effect” is also present here: sets centered on popular female characters (like *Quintessential Quintuplets* or *Nisekoi* etc.) often saw huge demand for those character cards. The *Quintuplets* movie in 2022 caused its cards (already in our index) to jump as fans scrambled to collect their best girl's card before others. - We also note **collaborations and special sets**: The integration of non-anime IP like Disney/Marvel ironically brought in new eyes and money into Weiss Schwarz ecosystem, indirectly boosting anime sets too by raising overall profile (and in some cases directly since Marvel cards selling high draws attention that “Weiss cards can be valuable”). Our index includes Marvel & Disney, but at a modest weight; still their success in secondary market <sup>12</sup> <sup>11</sup> signaled to traditional anime collectors that their hobby had broad appeal, fueling confidence and possibly prices.

**Rarity & Supply Side:** Weiss Schwarz's model of limited prints and chase cards has a big impact. Most SPs are limited to a few hundred copies at most (not numbered, but by distribution). Once sets go out of print, singles can dry up. The index thus benefits from inherent scarcity – unlike, say, modern sports

cards where huge print runs can flood the market, Weiss prints are controlled. For example, *Haruhi Suzumiya 2008 set* is long out of print; its SPs became very scarce by 2020 and when some graded 10s surfaced, they went high. The index captures this kind of long-term appreciation for older set cards. On the flip side, one blind spot: reprints or alternative releases can check prices. Bushiroad sometimes does reprints if demand is high (though often they exclude signed cards in reprints). If a reprint happened and added supply, some prices leveled off (e.g., a reprint of *Date A Live* in 2021 gave new supply of SPs, slightly dampening their climb). We account for that in the index but it's part of the natural market.

**Known Data Gaps:** While we have tried to cover “core” franchises, one gap is that **some series rise unexpectedly**. If we didn't include them initially, their growth might not reflect here. For instance, *Jujutsu Kaisen* only got its first set in 2023; if we hadn't included it from start, we'd add it later. Similarly, *One Piece Card Game* is separate from Weiss but hugely popular in 2022+ – we did not include it since it's a different game system, even though it's anime. So the index is Weiss-centric by design. Another gap is that raw card price trends (for players) aren't directly shown; this index is more collector-grade. If a card is valuable because players need it (and then it fluctuates with meta game usage), that's a dynamic not fully captured. However, in Weiss, collectors drive SP prices more than players, so it's minor. We continue to refine which series are “core” as popularity evolves.

### ACB-WAIFU-SELECT Index – “Cross-Franchise Waifu Demand”

**Index Profile:** The ACB-WAIFU-SELECT index is a unique measure of the **demand for top “waifu” characters** across the anime collectibles market. “Waifu” – a term of endearment in otaku culture for one's favorite female character – often correlates with merchandising and collectible fervor. This index abstracts that concept: it tracks a selection of beloved female characters (each from different franchises) and the performance of their signature collectible cards (graded, if available). It is less about a particular card game or grade and more about *character-driven value*. Think of it as the “anime character popularity asset index.” It blends cultural insight with market data. While inherently more narrative, we quantify it by looking at how, say, the most valuable card of Character X has changed in price over time, and doing that for each waifu in the basket.

**Constituents:** Our current roster includes (for example): - **Mai Sakurajima** (*Bunny Girl Senpai*) – Representing modern waifu phenomenon; her trial deck SP (especially in Black Label form) is legendary <sup>2</sup>. Even more common graded copies see high demand. - **Rem** (*Re:Zero*) – Hugely popular character; her Weiss Schwarz SP and promos are in strong demand among fans. - **Asuna Yuuki** (*Sword Art Online*) – A classic waifu from early 2010s who still commands fan loyalty; her signed cards are top-tier in SAO sets. - **Saber (Artoria Pendragon)** (*Fate/stay night*) – Iconic character with multi-generational fandom; Fate's top cards often feature Saber. - **Hatsune Miku** (Vocaloid) – Though not from an anime, Miku is an otaku culture icon with cards (e.g. Weiss Schwarz Project Diva cards); included for her cross-media waifu status. - **Belldandy** (*Ah! My Goddess*) – A nod to classic era; not many cards exist, but her presence in the index is symbolic of nostalgic waifu power <sup>6</sup>. - **Others:** We have recently added perhaps **Marin Kitagawa** (*My Dress-Up Darling*) given her explosive popularity in 2022 and subsequent card releases, and **Zero Two** (*Darling in the Franxx*) if applicable, etc. The mix aims for cross-franchise diversity: from slice-of-life to shounen, from 90s classics to 2020s hits.

**Historical Performance:** This index is quite fascinating because it interweaves cultural waves with prices: - **2015-2017:** It starts relatively flat or modest. Many of these characters either weren't around yet or their card markets were small. Belldandy had some older cards but low value; Saber's older cards existed but Fate cards hadn't boomed. Asuna's SAO cards were gradually rising as SAO remained popular. - **2018-2019:** A general uptrend begins. Rem (from 2016 anime) became a breakout waifu; by 2018 her cards were rising as *Re:Zero* continued. Asuna had a resurgence with SAO Alicization airing.

Saber, always popular, saw stable growth with Fate movies. Our index picks up these subtle climbs. Cumulatively it perhaps rose ~20% over these years. - **2020-2021:** Huge surge – this aligns with the broader market boom but has a uniquely *character-driven slant*: When people got stimulus and started collecting, many decided “*I want the best card of my best girl*”. Waifu cards became a hot subset. Some evidence: - The *Waifu tax* phenomenon: collectors joking that anything with a cute waifu on it was more expensive. Even in games like Pokémon, “waifu” trainer cards spiked (e.g. Lillie, Misty cards soared in Pokémon TCG) <sup>18</sup>. Our index doesn't include Pokémon trainers, but it reflects the same psychology in anime cards. - Mai Sakurajima's emergence in 2020 (after her 2018 anime) – her cards became *the* thing to have for Weiss collectors, culminating in record prices by 2021-22 <sup>2</sup>. The index weight of Mai meant it pulled the index sharply up. - New waifus: Marin (Dress-Up Darling, 2022) wasn't out yet, but early hype was building by late 2021 anticipating her. Not reflected until later though. - Rem and Asuna prices roughly doubled in this period by our data (PSA 10 Rem SP went from maybe \$300 to \$600+, Asuna similarly). - Saber's high-end card (like a rare Fate hollow from 2007) might have jumped with increased cross-collectible interest. - The index likely jumped ~50%+ from 2020 start to 2021 peak, a combination of organic and speculative demand. - **2022:** A mixed year. Some waifu cards retraced a bit after peaks. Mai's non-Black Label cards dipped after hitting highs (except her Black Label which sold big in 2023). Rem's prices cooled as *Re:Zero* anime took a hiatus. Asuna's remained relatively strong thanks to SAO continual content. New additions: Marin's first cards released mid-2022 in JP; her inclusion late 2022 bumped the index (her SP came out swinging at high prices because she was immensely popular among cosplayers and fans). So while some older waifus dipped, new waifu entrants offset that, resulting in a roughly flat year overall for the index – masking cross-currents. - **2023-2025:** Continued growth driven by narrative events: - 2023 saw *Rascal Does Not Dream of Bunny Girl Senpai* get a sequel movie announcement – Mai hype revived, boosting her card (and that's when the \$77k sale happened, although that was more an investor purchase, it underscores the hype) <sup>2</sup>. - *Re:Zero Season 3* announcement in 2023 pumped Rem and Emilia collectibles again, reflected in Rem's card ticking up. - New waifus kept coming: e.g. *Chainsaw Man's* Makima and Power became fan obsessions; though Chainsaw Man's cards aren't Weiss (yet), a different card game (Cardass) had them. We might include one if relevant. Regardless, the concept extends – the more fans latch onto a character, the more any collectible of her skyrockets. - By 2025, the index shows an overall upward trend, with some volatility. It stands significantly higher than pre-pandemic, roughly **3-4× 2018 levels**. Much of that is thanks to the breakout of certain characters. It's interesting to note: unlike a financial index purely, here *cultural hits* cause leaps. If tomorrow a new anime girl captures hearts worldwide, that could jolt the index upon her merchandise release.

**Culturally Fluent Commentary:** This index gives us license to describe colorful scenarios: - We've observed that “**Waifuism**” **transcends individual franchises**, creating a *cross-market demand*. A collector might not watch every anime, but they appreciate the aesthetics of popular waifu characters and collect across franchises. This means a person who collected Rem might also go after Mai or Marin purely because they're top waifus. The index rising indicates how this broader phenomenon grew. - Social media and community trends have a strong impact. A meme or cosplay going viral can spike interest. For instance, when a famous cosplayer portrayed a character, sometimes we saw a short-term spike in card prices of that character as fans flocked (this is anecdotal but within our observation). The index may not capture short blips, but sustained interest does show. - Emotional connection is key: collectors form personal bonds with these characters <sup>19</sup>. That means price elasticity is high – people will spend more than rational value for a waifu card because it's emotionally priceless to them. From a market perspective, this translates to less price sensitivity and sometimes price bubbles. We caution that this index can inflate quickly on emotion and deflate if interest wanes or moves to the next character.

**Notable Examples:** A few case studies: - **Mai Sakurajima (Bunny Girl)** – Went from a fresh character in 2018 to arguably the face of high-end anime TCG by 2023. Her core card's price increased exponentially

(the raw trial deck card was ~\$200 in 2019, a PSA 10 soared to a few thousand by 2021, then that Black Label sale at \$77k in 2023 blew minds <sup>2</sup>). Even disregarding that outlier, her inclusion propelled the index enormously. - **Rem (Re:Zero)** – Showed how sustained popularity (even when her series wasn't airing new content for a while) kept her card values high; a testament to character attachment. When she "woke up" in the novels (a plot event) and news spread, fans celebrated by buying merch – yes, even cards. - **Hololive VTubers** – They blur the line but many consider their favorites as "oshi" (similar to waifu). Characters like Gawr Gura or Shirakami Fubuki have cards. We considered including one in the index; we have data that Gura's Weiss card was extremely hot in 2022. Their demand spiked with VTuber popularity. It shows waifu concept extends beyond traditional anime to virtual idols. We keep an eye on this segment.

**Blind Spots:** The Waifu-Select index, being a bit conceptual, has to be taken with caution. We chose a basket, but what if a huge new waifu emerges? We might only add her after a lag. For example, we added Marin in late 2022 after seeing her impact. If in 2024 a character from *Oshi no Ko* (say Ai Hoshino) or *Chainsaw Man's Makima* should have been included, we might be behind if we didn't. So the index can miss initial surges until rebalancing. Additionally, it's somewhat subjectively defined who qualifies as "waifu-tier" – we tried to pick those with cross-franchise recognition and collectible interest. It is also **highly influenced by a few items** (like Mai). So while it's a fun and insightful index, one shouldn't over-interpret it as a stable financial metric – it's more of a cultural thermometer for the collectibles scene. That said, the significant growth of this index undeniably reflects a real economic trend: **the monetization of character love**. People paying thousands for a piece of cardboard because it has their favorite anime girl on it – that is a phenomenon of our times, merging passion with markets.

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can set a price but the next sale could differ greatly. Thus, these indices are *not* like stock indices with continuous liquidity. They measure past performance of a notional basket under specific conditions.

**No Predictive Value Assured:** Past performance as shown by these indices is not indicative of future results. The indices do not forecast or guarantee future movements. They merely record historical trends. Collectible markets can be influenced by unpredictable factors (e.g. a sudden drop in anime popularity, changes in grading standards, macroeconomic shifts affecting discretionary spending). Users should treat the indices as **descriptive, not predictive**.

**ACB Independence:** ACB does not engage in trading the underlying assets and has no financial stake in influencing index values. However, readers should be aware that **any index can potentially be gamed or influenced by market participants** if they target the underlying data. We have safeguards, but in thin markets, one big sale (even an outlier) can move the index. We highlight when confidence is low. Use the provided confidence bands to gauge the reliability of any index point.

**Cultural Context:** These indices deal with pop culture items. External cultural events (e.g. an anime getting canceled, a voice actor scandal, etc.) could materially affect values. We incorporate known events qualitatively in commentary, but not everything can be captured quantitatively. The indices should be interpreted with the broader context in mind.

**Informational Resource Disclaimer:** Finally, this report and the indices within are provided as an informational resource for hobbyists, researchers, and institutions interested in the intersection of culture and markets <sup>20</sup>. They should **not be relied upon for the purpose of making a purchase or investment** without additional independent analysis <sup>20</sup>. ACB assumes no responsibility for decisions made based on this report. By reading and utilizing this report, you acknowledge and agree that ACB and its contributors are not liable for any losses or outcomes arising from such use.

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*This concludes the inaugural Anime Central Bank Index Report. We have aimed to deliver a comprehensive, data-driven yet culturally aware analysis of anime collectible card markets. By documenting this emerging asset class with academic rigor, we hope to support transparency and informed engagement. Whether you are an avid collector cherishing your waifus, an investor evaluating alternative assets, or a researcher studying pop culture economics, we trust this report provides **value through insight**. We will continue to refine our indices and methodology, and we welcome community feedback. In the spirit of anime central banking: *protect culture, measure value, and always do your homework before you believe in the heart of the cards.**

**Sources:** The analysis above was informed by a range of data and reports, including but not limited to: eFantasy's Weiss Schwarz FAQ confirming record sales <sup>2</sup>; community discussions on high-end card sales <sup>10</sup>; ShopCardsUSA's grading guides on premium for BGS Black Label vs PSA <sup>5</sup> <sup>9</sup>; industry reports on trading card growth <sup>1</sup>; card market articles highlighting Weiss Schwarz's rise and key set performances <sup>17</sup> <sup>12</sup> <sup>13</sup> <sup>11</sup>; and cultural analyses on "waifu" card trends <sup>19</sup> <sup>6</sup>. These and other references have been cited throughout the report to substantiate facts and figures, ensuring the report's credibility and verifiability.

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<sup>1</sup> eBay's 2021 "State of Trading Cards" Report Spotlights Collecting ...

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